

Modern Indian Chai House

Bombay street food. Properly brewed chai. Modern café format.

40	\$35	22%	\$22K
SEATS	AVG SPEND	FOOD COST	EST. MONTHLY NET

// WHAT A MICHELIN-TRAINED CHEF SEES IN INDIAN COOKING

Indian spice work is architecture. The sequence in which spices enter a dish determines the flavour as much as the spices themselves. Whole spices bloomed in hot oil release fat-soluble aromatics that ground spices cannot. The tadka — the tempering of mustard seeds, curry leaves and dried chilli in hot oil that is poured over a finished dal — is not garnish. It is a second cooking stage that adds volatile aromatics lost in the initial cook. Masala chai brewed properly — whole spices simmered in water before milk is added, then boiled again together — produces a depth that a tea bag steeped in hot water cannot approach. The difference is chemistry. This guide teaches the chemistry.

// WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES

Indian food in America has been trapped in butter chicken and naan for thirty years. The operator who brings Bombay street food — vada pav, masala dosa, properly brewed chai — to a modern café format is entering a market with almost no direct competition. The food cost on masala chai is 11%. At 60 cups a day, that is a \$266 daily gross margin on one drink.

This guide is the blueprint for the café that captures that market.

Entrées

#	Dish	Time	Food Cost	Notes
1	Pani Puri	5 min	12%	Interactive — fill & eat in one bite

2	Samosa — Punjabi Style	6 min	14%	Contains gluten
3	Chaat — Papdi Chaat	5 min	13%	Cold assembly dish
4	Vada Pav — Bombay Street Slider	6 min	15%	Signature street item
5	Dahi Vada	4 min	11%	Contains dairy
6	Aloo Tikki — Spiced Potato Patty	7 min	12%	Pan-fried to order

Pani Puri

Pani Puri — Mumbai Street Style

Prep: 5 min · FC: 12% · Gluten (shells) · Serves: 6 pieces

- 1 Arrange 6 hollow semolina shells on serving tray. Ensure shells are crisp — discard any soft ones.
- 2 Fill two small ramekins: one with tamarind-date chutney, one with spiced mint-coriander water (pani).
- 3 Prepare filling: spiced chickpeas + boiled potato, seasoned with chaat masala, cumin, black salt.
- 4 Present to table with verbal instruction: fill shell, add pani, eat in one bite.

The pani temperature matters. Serve chilled — 4–6°C. The cold pani against room-temp shell creates the textural contrast the dish depends on.

Samosa — Punjabi Style

Prep: 6 min · FC: 14% · Contains: Gluten · Pre-assembled, fried to order

- 1 Pre-assembled samosas held refrigerated. Fry at 175°C for 4–5 min until golden and blistered.
- 2 Drain on rack 60 seconds. Do not paper-towel — steam softens the pastry.
- 3 Plate with green chutney and tamarind chutney. Dust with chaat masala.

The Punjabi samosa is larger and more heavily spiced than the South Indian version. Filling: potato, peas, cumin, coriander, garam masala, dried mango powder (amchur).

Mains

#	Dish	Time	FC	Notes
1	Butter Chicken Bowl	10 min	19%	Contains dairy
2	Dal Makhani	12 min	13%	Signature — 18hr cook

3	Chole Bhature	10 min	16%	Fried bread, pressure-cooked chickpeas
4	Masala Dosa	12 min	14%	GF — rice/lentil batter
5	Palak Paneer	10 min	17%	Contains dairy
6	Biryani — Chicken Dum	15 min	20%	May contain nuts
7	Aloo Paratha	8 min	12%	Griddle-cooked stuffed flatbread
8	Rajma Chawal	8 min	13%	Kidney bean curry + rice
9	Pav Bhaji	8 min	14%	Spiced veg mash on butter rolls
10	Egg Bhurji	7 min	11%	Indian scrambled eggs

Dal Makhani — Signature

Dal Makhani — 18-Hour Black Lentil

Prep: 12 min (day-of) · Total cook: 18 hrs · FC: 13% · Contains: Dairy · House Signature

- 1 Night before (17:00):** Soak whole black lentils (urad dal) + kidney beans 8 hrs. Pressure cook 45 min.
- 2** Transfer to heavy-bottomed pot. Add tomato purée, ginger-garlic paste, whole spices (cardamom, clove, bay). Simmer overnight on lowest heat — 10–12 hrs.
- 3 Morning check (06:00):** Stir, check consistency. Lentils should be completely broken down and silky. Add butter and cream.
- 4** Continue slow simmer until service. Finish each portion to order: ladle into bowl, finish with **1 tsp butter**, swirl of cream, dust of garam masala.

The 18-hour cook is the product. Do not attempt to shortcut it. The Maillard reaction on the lentil proteins during the overnight simmer creates compounds that a 2-hour cook cannot replicate. This is your signature — protect it.

13% 18hr #1

FOOD COSTCOOK TIMEBEST SELLER

Masala Dosa — South Indian Crepe

Prep: 12 min · FC: 14% · Gluten-Free (rice/lentil batter) · Batter fermented overnight

- 1 Batter check (08:00):** Fermented overnight rice-lentil batter should be aerated and slightly sour. Adjust consistency with water.
- 2** Heat cast iron griddle to **220°C**. Wipe with oil-soaked cloth. Pour 150ml batter, spread in outward spiral to thin crepe.
- 3** Add spiced potato filling (masala) to centre. Drizzle ghee around edges. Cook until underside is golden-crisp.
- 4** Fold, plate with sambar (lentil broth) and three chutneys: coconut, tomato, green.

The fermentation is non-negotiable. It provides the sour flavour and the bubbles that create the dosa's characteristic crisp-lacy texture. 8-hour minimum, 12-hour optimal.

Mains — Continued

Biryani — Chicken Dum

Prep: 15 min · FC: 20% · May contain nuts · Dum cooking method

- 1 **Prep (11:00):** Marinate chicken in yogurt, spices, saffron 2+ hrs. Par-cook basmati rice to 70% done.
- 2 Layer: chicken masala base → par-cooked rice → fried onions → mint → saffron milk → ghee.
- 3 Seal pot with dough or foil. Dum cook at **160°C** 25 min. Hold in oven. Portion to order.
- 4 Serve with raita and mirchi ka salan (chili gravy). Garnish: fried onions, boiled egg.

Dum means "breath" — the sealed steam cook. The dough seal is traditional and keeps all aromatics inside. The first lift of the lid at the table is the theatre.

Pav Bhaji — Bombay Spiced Veg Mash

Prep: 8 min · FC: 14% · Vegan base (butter optional)

- 1 Hold bhaji (spiced potato-vegetable mash) in bain-marie. Order: ladle onto flat griddle, heat through with butter knob.
- 2 Griddle-toast pav buns with generous butter until golden-crisp on cut side.
- 3 Plate bhaji topped with raw onion, coriander, lemon wedge, butter curl. Buns alongside.

Desserts

#	Dish	Time	FC	Notes
1	Gulab Jamun	3 min	9%	Dairy, Gluten — best with masala chai
2	Kulfi — Indian Ice Cream	2 min	11%	Dairy, Nuts
3	Mango Shrikhand	3 min	10%	Dairy — strained yogurt, mango
4	Phirni — Rose Rice Pudding	3 min	10%	Dairy — serve chilled

Gulab Jamun — Sugar Syrup Dumplings

Prep: 3 min · FC: 9% · Contains: Dairy, Gluten · Pairs: Masala Chai

- 1 Hold gulab jamun in warm rose-cardamom sugar syrup **60°C**. Do not boil — syrup will crystallise.
- 2 Plate 3 pieces per portion. Drizzle with syrup. Optional: small scoop of malai (clotted cream) alongside.
- 3 Always offer masala chai pairing. Use script: "The gulab jamun is best with the masala chai."

FC 9% on a dessert is exceptional. At an average \$6 sell price, gross margin per portion is

\$5.46. Push this dish at every dessert pitch.

Drinks Menu

Masala Chai — House Spiced Tea

\$4.99 · FC: 11%

Mango Lassi

\$6.99

Rose Lassi

\$6.99

Nimbu Pani — Indian Lemonade

\$4.99

Thandai — Spiced Almond Milk

\$5.99

Filter Coffee — South Indian

\$4.99

Jaljeera — Cumin-Tamarind Soda

\$4.99

Aam Panna — Raw Mango Cooler

\$5.99

Masala Chai — House Method

Masala Chai — Brewed In-House

\$4.99 · FC: 11% · 60 cups/day = \$266 daily gross margin

- 1 **Spice base (07:00):** Crush whole spices: green cardamom, black pepper, cinnamon stick, cloves, ginger (fresh). Toast dry 90 seconds.
- 2 Simmer crushed spices in water **95°C** for 20 minutes. Add Assam tea leaves. Simmer 3 minutes more.
- 3 Add full-fat milk. Bring to boil, watching carefully — milk boils fast. Reduce, simmer 2 min.
- 4 Strain through fine mesh. Add sugar to taste. Serve in small steel cup (cutting chai style) or ceramic.

This is not tea with milk added. The second boil after milk is critical — it extracts different compounds and rounds the spice profile. A bag steeped in hot water and splashed with milk is a different product entirely. Train staff to explain this distinction.

11%

\$266

\$7,980

FOOD COST DAILY MARGIN @ 60 MONTHLY CHAI MARGIN

Service Scripts

These scripts are trained dialogue — not verbatim reads. Deliver naturally. The goal is to add context that makes the dish worth more to the guest.

SCRIPT 01 — WELCOME + MASALA CHAI PITCH

"The chai is brewed in-house — whole spices simmered 20 minutes before the milk goes in. \$4.99. It's not a bag in hot water. You'll taste the difference."

SCRIPT 02 — PANI PURI TABLE EXPERIENCE

"The pani puri is interactive — we bring six hollow crisp shells and two chutneys, you fill them yourself and eat in one bite. It's street food the way it's eaten in Mumbai."

SCRIPT 03 — DAL MAKHANI EXPLANATION

"The dal has been cooking since yesterday. 18 hours. Black lentils, butter, cream, tomato — it needs that time for the lentils to break down and absorb the spices. It's our best dish."

SCRIPT 04 — DESSERT + CHAI PAIRING

"The gulab jamun is best with the masala chai — the sugar syrup and the spiced milk are made for each other. That's how it's served at weddings in India."

SCRIPT 05 — RETURN VISIT

"Saturday mornings we do a full Bombay street breakfast — pav bhaji, vada pav, cutting chai. Different menu, different vibe. Worth coming back for."

Script 02 (pani puri) and Script 03 (dal makhani) are your highest-value upsell moments. The interactive experience justifies a premium order. The 18-hour cook story converts first-timers into regulars — they return to verify the story is real.

Daily Prep Schedule

Time	Task	Owner	Notes
06:00	Dal makhani overnight check	Head Chef	Check consistency, stir, adjust heat
07:00	Chai spice base prep	Chai station	20-min spice simmer — do not skip
08:00	Dosa batter check	Grill station	Fermented overnight — check aeration & sourness
09:00	Samosa assembly	Prep cook	Assemble & refrigerate — fry to order
10:00	Chole pressure cook	Prep cook	Chickpeas 45 min, then masala base
11:00	Biryani dum prep	Head Chef	Layer & seal — dum at 160°C for service
12:00	Lunch service opens	All stations	Full menu available
15:00	Afternoon reset	All	Restock, clean stations, prep dinner mise
17:00	Second dal batch	Head Chef	Overnight batch for next day — start now
18:30	Dinner service opens	All stations	Full menu + dinner specials
22:00	Close	All	Clean down, set overnight dal, prep notes

⚠ Allergen Matrix

Dish	Allergens
Samosa	GLUTEN
Pani Puri	GLUTEN
Dahi Vada	DAIRY
Butter Chicken	DAIRY
Dal Makhani	DAIRY
Masala Dosa	GF — RICE/LENTIL
Biryani — Chicken Dum	MAY CONTAIN NUTS
Gulab Jamun	DAIRY GLUTEN
Kulfi	DAIRY NUTS

P&L Overview

Period	Revenue	
Daily	~\$2,800	
Weekly	~\$16,800	
Monthly	~\$72,800	

Cost Category	%	Monthly (~)
Food Cost	22%	~\$16,016
Labour	28%	~\$20,384
Overheads	15%	~\$10,920
Net Profit	~35%	~\$25,480/month

\$72,800 22% 35% \$25,480

MONTHLY REVENUEFOOD COSTNET MARGINMONTHLY NET

Chai Economics

Metric	Value
Sell Price	\$4.99
Food Cost %	11%
Cost per Cup	~\$0.55
Gross Margin per Cup	~\$4.44
Daily @ 60 cups	~\$266 gross margin
Monthly @ 60/day	~\$7,980 from chai alone

The masala chai is your highest-margin product per unit. It should be the first thing every guest is offered, and the last. Staff who consistently upsell chai add thousands per month to the bottom line with a single sentence at each table.

// OPERATOR'S ADVANTAGE

The 35% net margin is achievable because Indian street food has naturally low food costs — legumes, rice, flour, spices are cheap. The premium comes from technique, knowledge, and execution. You are not competing with Indian buffets at \$13.99 all-you-can-eat. You are competing with modern café formats, and winning on margin, authenticity, and story.

